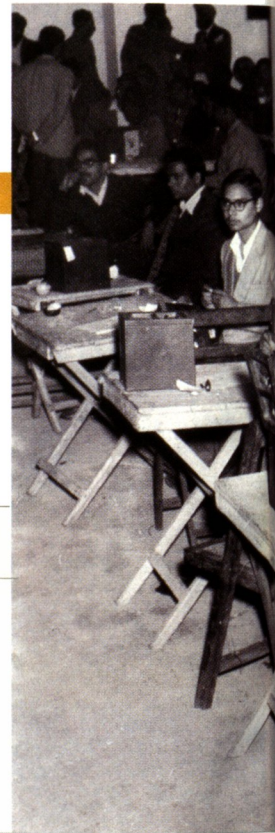


1952

THE FIRST COUNT

◀◀ REWIND

There were 18,000 candidates for 4,500 seats, 497 of which were in the Lok Sabha, during the first general elections. One-hundred-and-seventy-six million Indians, 85 per cent of whom couldn't read or write, formed the electorate. There were 2,24,000 polling booths and as many policemen pressed into service. Symbols were used on ballot papers for voters who couldn't read. When the results came in, the Congress led by Jawaharlal Nehru had swept into power winning 364 of the 489 seats in Parliament.



VOTING FOR INDIA Sukumar Sen



Appointed Chief Election Commissioner, the ICS officer had the unenviable task of conducting the first two general elections in independent India. He supervised voter registration, design of party symbols and recruitment of honest polling officers. Add to that an electorate spread over more than million square miles. The second election in 1957 cost India Rs 45 million less. Reason: The prudent Sen had safely stored the 3.5 million ballot boxes used the first time round.

DMK'S ICON

With a famous courtroom scene that lasted five minutes, *Parashakti* starring the legendary Sivaji Ganesan, had its dialogues crafted by future Tamil Nadu chief minister M. Karunanidhi. The film was also considered a DMK-vehicle as it dispersed the party's ideals and made Ganesan a DMK icon.



OLYMPIAN FEATS

In the 1952 Summer Olympics in Helsinki, India won a gold in hockey defeating Holland 6-1. Balbir Singh Sr. scored five of India's six goals. Wrestler K.D. Jadhav won a bronze medal, the only time the country won more than one medal.

FIRST CUT

- India launched a family planning programme, the first in the world.
- The first International Film Festival was inaugurated at Bombay.

- The first radio telescope was installed at Calcutta.
- The first general budget was presented in Parliament.
- India won its first ever cricket Test match, defeating England in Madras.